



» FIGHT CLUB

Big shoes to fill. The last name 'Nurmagomedov' carries a heightened sense of greatness, owing to MMA legend Khabib Nurmagomedov's legacy, something which fans should consider when looking at Umar (in pic). GETTY IMAGES

THE NAME'S NURMAGOMEDOV

Umar Nurmagomedov is keen to **carry forward the legacy** of his famous cousin, Khabib, as he prepares for his potential upcoming fight with Bekzat Almakhan.

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Russia has a long and established history of producing successful fighters across various combat sports, and the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) is no exception, the latest being Umar Nurmagomedov.

The last name 'Nurmagomedov' carries a heightened sense of greatness, owing to MMA legend Khabib Nurmagomedov's legacy, something which fans should consider when looking at Umar. His spectacular knockout win over Raoni Barcelos at UFC Fight Night: Strickland vs Imavov further proved that he is the real deal.

Born in Dagestan in 1996, Umar competes in the bantamweight division. Fighting professionally

since 2016, Umar's record is 16-0, including four wins in the UFC, where he made his debut in 2021.

A unique problem

A ranked fighter, on average, will compete two to three times a year based on his fitness and the ability to keep winning. Despite having both these qualities, Umar has struggled to find opponents.

The biggest hurdle that Umar has faced so far in his UFC career is inactivity, as his only opportunity to take the octagon in 2023 came in January. Although he was scheduled to face Cory Sandhagen in August, the matchup got cancelled after Umar suffered a shoulder injury.

His absence in the octagon has resulted in frustration, and the bantamweight fighter even vented his frustration on social media platform, X.

Ranked fighters are hesitant to take on Umar due to an apparent fear that the Russian has created. He has not just won four fights in the UFC, but has made sure that all of those were outright, statement victories. His four wins constitute two submissions, one unanimous decision, and the latest one being a technical knockout win.

A bizarre solution

According to multiple reports, after constant failures in finding an opponent, the UFC matchmakers have gone out of their way and have called up Bekzat Almakhan, a debutant, to materialise a fight for the highly-rated Umar. The contest is about to be added to UFC Fight Night: Rozenstruik vs Gaziev, scheduled for March 3.

Almakhan, 26, has 15 finishes in 17 victories, including 13 knockouts. He enters the promotion on a nine-fight winning streak. His last loss dates back to June 2021. Almakhan most recently competed under the Octagon and UAE Warriors banners.

With a fighting style similar to that of his cousin, Umar is dominant on the ground and strong with the clinch; the rear-naked choke being his go-to weapon of choice. Based on his undefeated fighting record, he appears to be on course to creating his own legacy, like Khabib.